Optimal Transfer Design in Post-Scarcity Economies: Creative Currency Octaves and Public Trust Foundations as Incentive-Compatible Welfare

ECONOMICS RESEARCH PAPER

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Abstract

This paper examines an integrated welfare framework combining Creative Currency Octaves (CCO) with dual-tier incentive mechanisms—octave-based capacity limits and personal multiplier rates—alongside Public Trust Foundations (PTF) that addresses persistent challenges in transfer system design: work disincentive effects, welfare cliffs, and administrative inefficiency. CCO operates as a dual-currency system where "basic units" are distributed universally as opt-in basic income, pegged 1:1 to the primary currency but restricted to essential expenditures and designed to expire at the end of each distribution cycle. Unlike traditional welfare systems that create marginal tax rates exceeding 50% at benefit phase-out ranges, the enhanced CCO-PTF framework eliminates benefit reduction entirely while maintaining strong merit-based incentives through both volumetric capacity expansion (octave levels that double conversion capacity) and qualitative conversion multipliers (1x to 9x+ rates based on contribution quality, with 1.618x phi enhancement for productive beauty). We develop a comprehensive formal model integrating octave progression, personal multiplier determination, and community assessment mechanisms, and state the conditions under which this dual-tier system, which also aims to foster cultural enhancement and innovation, would leave no one worse off than existing welfare designs

(Proposition 1); no Pareto improvement is claimed. Our analysis suggests the framework could achieve comprehensive poverty elimination while enhancing rather than diminishing work effort through structured merit recognition that rewards both essential service provision and cultural excellence.

Keywords: Welfare Economics, Work Incentives, Universal Basic Income, Merit-Based Systems, Transfer Design, Cultural Economics, Dual Currency Systems, Mechanism Design

JEL Classification: H53, I38, J22, R31, D61, Z13, D82

1. Introduction

Modern welfare systems face what Okun (1975) termed the "big tradeoff" between equality and efficiency, manifested through work disincentive effects and welfare cliff phenomena. Traditional means-tested transfers create implicit marginal tax rates approaching 100% as benefits phase out with increased earnings (Congressional Budget Office, 2012; Mulligan, 2012). Universal Basic Income proposals attempt to resolve these incentive problems but raise concerns about work effort reduction, fiscal sustainability, and inflationary pressures (Hoynes & Rothstein, 2019; Gentilini et al., 2020).

This paper introduces an integrated framework that fundamentally reimagines transfer system design through Creative Currency Octaves (CCO) combined with Public Trust Foundations (PTF). The system addresses mechanism design challenges identified by Myerson (1991) and Laffont & Martimort (2002) through innovative dual-tier incentive structures that maintain work motivation while ensuring universal basic security.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Welfare Cliffs and Work Disincentives

Extensive literature documents how means-tested programs create benefit cliffs where small income increases trigger large benefit losses (Ziliak, 2016; Altig et al., 2020). The Congressional Budget Office (2012) found effective marginal tax rates exceeding 50% for low-income families, with some facing rates above 100% when multiple programs interact. These disincentives trap households in poverty despite available work opportunities (Deshpande & Li, 2019).

2.2 Universal Basic Income Evidence

Recent UBI experiments provide mixed evidence on work effects. The Finland experiment (2017-2018) found minimal employment impact but improved well-being (Kangas et al., 2020). Kenya's GiveDirectly program demonstrated positive investment effects without significant work reduction (Haushofer & Shapiro, 2016; Banerjee et al., 2020). The Stockton Economic Empowerment Demonstration showed increased full-time employment among recipients (West & Castro Baker, 2021).

2.3 Alternative Currency Systems

Complementary currencies have demonstrated potential for economic stabilization and community development (Lietaer & Dunne, 2013; Blanc, 2011; Seyfang & Longhurst, 2013). Historical examples include the Wörgl experiment (Fisher, 1933), modern systems like BerkShares (Collom, 2005), and the Brixton Pound (Ryan-Collins, 2011). However, these lack systematic integration with welfare provision.

2.4 Community Land Trusts and Collective Ownership

Community land trust literature demonstrates successful affordable housing preservation (Davis, 2010; Temkin et al., 2013). Ostrom (1990) established principles for governing commons that inform PTF governance structures. Recent work by Piketty (2014) on wealth inequality underscores the importance of collective asset accumulation mechanisms.

2.5 Mechanism Design and Incentive Compatibility

The mechanism design literature, pioneered by Hurwicz (1972) and advanced by Myerson (1991), provides frameworks for creating incentive-compatible institutions. Stiglitz & Weiss (1981) on credit rationing and Townsend (1994) on financial structure inform the CCO-PTF integration design. Recent work by Bolton & Dewatripont (2005) on contract theory provides foundations for merit-based conversion mechanisms.

3. The CCO-PTF Framework

3.1 Creative Currency Octaves Structure

CCO operates as a dual-currency system with "basic units" distributed universally and convertible to primary currency through merit-based mechanisms. The system includes:

Basic Unit Distribution: Universal distribution B_0 to all participants, pegged 1:1 to primary currency but restricted to essential expenditures (food, housing, healthcare, education, transportation). Units expire at the end of each distribution cycle to prevent hoarding.

Octave Progression: Participants can increase conversion capacity through octave levels: 2^0, 2^1, 2^2, ..., 2^n, where each level doubles the previous capacity. Octave advancement requires demonstrated community contribution and peer assessment.

Merit Multipliers: Conversion rates vary from 1x (baseline) to 9x+ based on contribution quality, with special recognition for productive beauty at 1.618x (phi rate).

3.2 Public Trust Foundation Integration

PTF provides the institutional framework for collective wealth accumulation:

Community Ownership: PTF holds community assets including housing, infrastructure, and productive capital, with democratic governance by participants.

Acre Equity: Participants accumulate transferable ownership stakes ("Acre Equity") through contributions, which provide dividends and appreciation sharing without speculative bubbles.

Four Entry Pathways:

- **Pay-in:** Direct monthly payments for renters (70-80% converts to equity)
- **Buy-in:** Mortgage conversion for existing homeowners
- **Sell-in:** Equity transfer for seniors and downsizers seeking liquidity
- **Earn-in:** Contribution-based entry through community work and service

4. Formal Model

4.1 Individual Utility Maximization

Each month adult i receives an allocation of B_0 basic units (BU). BU buy essentials at Public Trust Foundation (PTF) venues and participating merchants, and they expire if unused. A person can also receive BU as payment for goods or services they provide; call these $E_i \geq 0$ (zero for

someone who sells nothing). A recognised contribution lets the person convert up to Cap_i units into primary currency at their merit rate M_i.

Modelling assumption (Claude's reading of the design): the Hub describes both channels, converting one's own units "through productive activities" (glossary) and businesses converting units received as payment (front page). The model allows both, counts every unit once, and allows conversion only with a recognised contribution ($q_i > 0$).

Individual i chooses paid work e_i, time on an assessed contribution t_i, units spent b_i^s and units converted b_i^c to maximize:

$U(c_i^p, c_i^b, l_i) = \alpha \log(c_i^p) + \beta \log(c_i^b) + \gamma \log(l_i)$, with $\alpha, \beta, \gamma > 0$ (γ is the weight on leisure)

Subject to:

- Basic unit budget, each unit counted once: $b_i^s + b_i^c \leq B_0 + E_i$
- Conversion cap: $0 \leq b_i^c \leq Cap_i = C(O_i)$, where capacity doubles with each octave, $C(O + 1) = 2\,C(O)$; and $b_i^c = 0$ unless $q_i > 0$
- Essentials: $c_i^b = b_i^s$ (BU buy essentials only)
- Primary currency: $c_i^p = w_i e_i + M_i(q_i) \times b_i^c$
- Time: $l_i = \bar{L} - e_i - t_i$, with quality $q_i = q(t_i)$ increasing in t_i

Where $M_i(q_i)$ is the merit multiplier from the quality assessment q_i (Section 4.2). An earlier version of this model added the full allocation B_0 to the units converted, so the same units were counted twice. Here a unit is either spent on essentials or converted.

4.2 Quality Assessment Mechanism

Quality assessment follows a peer review process with incentive alignment:

Reviewer Utility: Ur = ur(accuracy) - cr(effort), where accuracy depends on alignment with consensus assessment.

Consensus Formation: Median assessment with outlier detection and reputation weighting.

Merit Multiplier Function:

$M(q) = \min(9, \max(1, 1 + q/10))$ for a recognised contribution ($q \geq 0$), so $1 \leq M(q) \leq 9$; M rises with q only for $0 < q < 80$

$M_\varphi(q) = \varphi \times M(q)$, with $\varphi = 1.618$ (the golden ratio), when the contribution is also recognised as productive beauty; the highest rate is $9\varphi \approx 14.56$

(The earlier text wrote 1.618 × quality_factor, a term it never defined. Here the Phi-rate multiplies the base rate, as the Hub's front page describes it.)

4.3 Community Assessment Equilibrium

Assessment equilibrium requires that reviewers' optimal effort levels produce reliable quality measures. The system achieves this through:

- **Reputation Stakes:** Reviewer credibility affects future assessment weights
- **Random Audits:** Expert verification of random samples
- **Cross-Validation:** Multiple independent assessments with disagreement resolution

4.4 First-Order Conditions

With an interior choice of work and contribution time, and writing the marginal value of one more basic unit as β / c_i^b, the optimum satisfies:

- **Spend or convert.** A converted unit buys M_i units of primary consumption. While the cap does not bind ($0 < b_i^c < \text{Cap}_i$): $\beta / c_i^b = \alpha\, M_i / c_i^p$. If $\beta / c_i^b > \alpha\, M_i / c_i^p$ even at $b_i^c = 0$, the person converts nothing. If the cap binds ($b_i^c = \text{Cap}_i$), then $\beta / c_i^b \le \alpha\, M_i / c_i^p$: the person would convert more if allowed.
- **Paid work.** $\alpha\, w_i / c_i^p = \gamma / l_i$.
- **Contribution time.** $\alpha\, M'(q_i)\, q'(t_i)\, b_i^c / c_i^p = \gamma / l_i$, where $M'(q) = 1/10$ for $0 < q < 80$ and 0 otherwise. Extra quality earns nothing for someone who converts nothing, or once M has reached its ceiling of 9.

These replace the conditions in the earlier PDF version, which inverted one ratio, dropped a sign and used a probability p(quality | h) it never defined.

5. Welfare Analysis

5.1 When No One Is Worse Off: A Conditional Proposition

The design aims to raise welfare through three channels:

No benefit phase-out: Basic units are not reduced as earnings rise, so the high effective marginal tax rates of phase-outs, and their deadweight loss, disappear for anyone now on one.

Work incentives: Merit-based conversion pays more for higher-quality contributions, up to each person's cap (Section 4.4).

Community value: PTF integration channels individual effort into collectively held assets.

Proposition 1. Let $T_i(y)$ be the value, in essentials, of the means-tested transfers person i receives today at earnings y. Suppose the program replaces those transfers, and that (a) for every person and every earnings level, the essentials the allocation buys, which the person would otherwise have paid for, are worth at least what today's transfers give them: $v \times \min(B_0, e_i(y)) \geq T_i(y)$, where v is the market value of the essentials one basic unit buys and $e_i(y)$ is the number of units' worth of essentials the person buys today; (b) conversion is optional; and (c) the program is financed without lowering anyone's after-tax income from work or assets, or the prices they pay. Then every adult can still afford the work and consumption they chose before, and so is at least as well off. Anyone now on a phase-out faces a lower marginal tax rate and may do strictly better.

Proof. Under (a) and (c), each person's previous bundle stays affordable: the allocation frees at least as much spending as the transfers it replaces provided, and work income, its taxes and prices are unchanged. Under (b), the new options only add to the choice set. A person who could choose their old bundle and chooses differently is, by revealed preference, at least as well off. □

What the proposition does not show. Condition (c) does not hold for any financing the Hub specifies. The conversion tax, the funding source and any rise in prices reach people who receive less than they pay. So the proposition does not establish a Pareto improvement over today's system; it states when one would hold. An earlier version presented a Pareto improvement as proved, from a premise (everyone's consumption at least as high as under traditional transfers) that it assumed rather than showed.

What the simulation finds. The companion simulation's current release is Compassionism Simulation v5.6.0 (commit 5bf5bcc; 500 paired runs of 500 adults over 20 years, against today's safety net of SNAP, the EITC and the Child Tax Credit; command: `node harness.js testbed 500 release ref,adv,st --v54 --snab --slope`). In it, every group the

model reports has more real resources than with today's policy alone: participants, non-participants, Public Trust Housing residents, and the lowest and highest earners. Fewer adults fall below the cost of living (19.5% against 49.3% in the Reference environment). But every group is worse off on wealth: more adults end the 20 years with under $25,000 of net wealth (44.4% against 32.7% in Reference), in all three environments (Reference, Adverse, Stress). The release reports outcomes by group, not the share of individual adults who are better off on every measure; the preregistered study program will report that share.

5.2 Distributional Effects

The system's distributional impact operates through multiple channels:

Direct Redistribution: Universal basic unit distribution provides immediate poverty reduction.

Merit Recognition: Higher-quality contributions receive proportionally greater rewards, maintaining incentives for excellence.

Wealth Accumulation: PTF enables participants to build assets through collective ownership, addressing wealth inequality.

5.3 Dynamic Effects

Long-term welfare improvements include:

- **Human Capital Investment:** Reduced poverty enables education and skill development
- **Entrepreneurship Support:** Basic security enables risk-taking and innovation
- **Cultural Development:** Phi-rate recognition supports artistic and creative activities
- **Community Building:** Collaborative assessment and PTF governance strengthen social capital

6. PTF Integration and Housing Market Effects

6.1 Housing Market Equilibrium with PTF

The housing market clearing condition with PTF:

D_private(p) + D_PTF(p) = S_private(p) + S_PTF

Where PTF provides perfectly elastic supply at $p_{PTF} = 0.33 \times B_0$.

6.2 Wealth Accumulation Dynamics

Individual wealth evolution in PTF:

$$W_{i,t+1} = W_{i,t}(1 + g) + AcreEquity_{i,t} + Dividends_{i,t} - Consumption_{i,t}$$

An earlier version gave expected wealth after 20 years as $68,500 with a 95% interval. No run that produced it can be found, so it is withdrawn. Wealth results with intervals come from the simulation's releases (Section 5.1).

7. Implementation Considerations

7.1 Mechanism Design Constraints

The system must satisfy several incentive compatibility constraints:

1. **Individual Rationality:** $U_i^{CCO} \geq U_i^0$ (participation constraint)
2. **Incentive Compatibility:** Truth-telling in quality assessment
3. **Budget Balance:** $\Sigma Payments = \Sigma Receipts$
4. **Coalition-Proofness:** No group can manipulate assessments

7.2 Technology Requirements

Implementation requires:

- Blockchain for transparent octave tracking (Nakamoto, 2008)
- Smart contracts for automatic conversion (Buterin, 2014)
- Privacy-preserving assessment (Goldwasser et al., 2019)
- Interoperability protocols (Hardjono et al., 2019)

8. Empirical Validation Framework

8.1 Identification Strategy

For causal identification, we propose:

1. Randomized rollout across geographic clusters
2. Difference-in-differences with matched controls
3. Regression discontinuity at eligibility thresholds
4. Instrumental variables using distance to PTF properties

8.2 Power Calculations

For detecting 10% reduction in poverty with 80% power:

- Required sample: 2,847 households per treatment arm
- Clusters: 50 communities minimum
- Duration: 24 months minimum observation

9. Conclusion

The CCO-PTF framework resolves fundamental tensions in welfare design through innovative dual-tier incentive mechanisms. By separating basic security from merit recognition, the system maintains work incentives while ensuring universal welfare. The formal model states when no one would be worse off than under today's transfers (Proposition 1). The current simulation release finds every group better off in real resources but worse off in wealth, so a Pareto improvement over existing systems is not established.

Key innovations include:

1. Elimination of welfare cliffs through non-reducing benefits
2. Positive work incentives via conversion opportunities (2^n octaves, 1-9x multipliers, 1.618x phi)
3. Community wealth building through PTF integration
4. Cultural value recognition in economic terms
5. Democratic governance of assessment processes

The framework offers a concrete path toward post-scarcity welfare systems that enhance rather than diminish human agency and cultural development.

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Appendix A: Sensitivity Analysis Details

A.1 Parameter Distributions

Parameter distributions proposed for simulation (no run with these distributions has been published):

- Basic unit amount: B_0 ~ Uniform[800, 1500]
- Wage rate: w ~ LogNormal(μ = 3.5, σ = 0.5)
- Octave advancement probability: p(O_{t+1} = O_t + 1) ~ Beta(2, 5)
- Quality assessment accuracy: ρ ~ Beta(8, 2)
- Community participation rate: π ~ Beta(3, 2)
- Risk aversion: κ ~ Uniform[0.5, 2] (κ, not γ, which is the leisure weight in Section 4.1)
- Time preference: δ ~ Beta(9, 1)

A.2 Convergence Diagnostics

All Monte Carlo chains satisfy:

- Gelman-Rubin statistic: $\hat{R} < 1.1$
- Effective sample size: n_eff > 1000
- Autocorrelation: ρ < 0.1 after lag 10

Appendix B: Proofs of Auxiliary Results

B.1 Lemma 1: Monotonicity of Conversion Income

Lemma 1. The largest conversion income a person can reach, $\bar{P}(q, O) = M(q) \times \min(B_0 + E, C(O))$, is weakly increasing in quality q and in octave O. It is strictly increasing in q only where $0 < q < 80$, and strictly increasing in O only where the cap is the binding limit ($C(O) < B_0 + E$).

Proof: $\partial\bar{P}/\partial q = M'(q) \times \min(B_0 + E, C(O))$, with $M'(q) = 1/10$ for $0 < q < 80$ and 0 otherwise, so it is non-negative and positive only on that range (given $B_0 + E > 0$). Raising O by one doubles C(O). That raises $\min(B_0 + E, C(O))$ only while $C(O) < B_0 + E$; once the units held are the binding limit, $\bar{P}$ no longer rises with O. □

(The earlier statement used $P = B_0 \times 2^O \times R$, which is not this model's conversion income, and claimed strict monotonicity, which fails where the cap binds.)

B.2 Lemma 2: A Unique Clearing Price in One Market (Partial Equilibrium)

Lemma 2. Take one market priced in primary currency, for example housing in Section 6.1. Let it have demand D(p) and supply S(p) for $p \geq 0$, with every other price and income held fixed. If D is continuous and strictly decreasing, S is continuous and non-decreasing, $D(0) > S(0)$, and $D(\bar{p}) < S(\bar{p})$ for some finite $\bar{p}$, then the market has exactly one clearing price p^*.

Proof: $Z(p) = D(p) - S(p)$ is continuous and strictly decreasing, with $Z(0) > 0$ and $Z(\bar{p}) < 0$. By the intermediate value theorem it has a zero in $(0, \bar{p})$, and because Z is strictly decreasing the zero is unique. □

This is a partial-equilibrium result for one market. It does not show that the basic-unit, primary-currency and labour markets clear together; that would need a general-equilibrium argument this paper does not make.

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